

Styles of fighting
Ancient Greek images of warfare often depict men fighting with a sword and a small oval "Boeotian" shield *(far left)*. It is not clear whether this shield and style of fighting belong to an earlier heroic age or were still in use when war was dominated by hoplites in phalanxes. The shield was clearly held differently from the larger round shield carried by hoplites *(left)*.

The increasing effectiveness of light troops led to changes in hoplite equipment and tactics. In the early 4th century the Athenian general Iphicrates stripped his hoplites of their metal greaves and cuirass, and replaced their large bronze-covered shield with a smaller shield faced with leather. More lightly equipped, the Iphicratid hoplite was better able to face the challenge presented by the peltasts and other skirmishers. At the same time, he was given a longer spear to outreach more heavily armoured hoplite opponents.

In general, Greek warfare underwent a gradual professionalization. Campaigns became too sustained and ambitious in scale to be conducted as a part-time activity by citizen-soldiers. Regular troops and mercenaries could provide specialist skills on the battlefield and conduct long, drawn-out sieges of fortified towns. Under the leadership of a military genius, Epaminondas, the Thebans became the dominant military force in Greece around 380 BCE with an army sharply different from the Athenian or Spartan forces that had fought Persia. At the heart of the Theban army was a body of full-time soldiers paid by the state, the Sacred Band. This elite force took the principle of comradely bonding to its limit, being composed apparently of homosexual couples. Theban tactics included an innovative use of the phalanx and a major role for cavalry, who were supported by lightly clad runners trained to keep up with the horses on foot. For battle the cream of the Theban hoplites, including the Sacred Band, were typically massed in a phalanx up to 48 ranks deep on the left wing, this shock force destroying the enemy while cavalry and light troops protected the centre and right.

MACEDONIANS AND ROMANS

From 337 BCE, the Greek city-states came under the dominance of Macedonian rulers, first Philip II and then his son, Alexander the Great. Hoplites became a crucial but secondary element in Macedonian-led armies, which had cavalry as their elite arm. On his astonishing campaigns of conquest from 334 to 323 BCE, Alexander used a phalanx 16 or 32 ranks deep, armed with the long "sarissa" spear, measuring 6-7m (20–23ft).

The hoplites were no longer self-consciously brave and noble citizen-soldiers, but relatively lower-class professionals drilled into a steady performance on the battlefield. Many Greeks also fought against Alexander, for their renowned qualities as armoured foot soldiers had made them sought-after mercenaries, whose services were bought by Persian emperors, as well as many other rulers in the eastern Mediterranean.

The hoplite style of warfare with phalanx and spear continued to show its worth until the armies of the Hellenistic world came into conflict with the rising power of Rome in the 2nd century BCE. At the decisive battle of Pydna in 168 BCE, the Romans deliberately retired over rough ground, which caused the pursuing Macedonians to lose their tight formation. The Roman infantry, armed with swords and javelins, were then able to slash a path into their phalanx. Once the fighting was at close quarters the long, unwieldy sarissa became a useless encumbrance. Hoplites threw away their spears and fought with daggers, but were cut to pieces by the Roman swords. A new era of infantry warfare was born.

HOPLITE BATTLE TACTICS

The tactics illustrated here are those of the 5th century BCE, when the tightly packed phalanxes of two opposing Greek city-states would line up to do battle in exactly the same formation. The men at the front advanced with their shields locked together and their spears ready to engage with the enemy. When the front ranks clashed, the men behind pressed forward with their shields on those ahead of them, contributing to the *othismos*, or "shoving match", with the rival phalanx. The details of Greek hoplite tactics are, however, the subject of dispute. Some historians have argued that as hoplites ran to attack they would have been forced to spread out, although they could have locked shields if standing on the defensive.

Advancing in a tight phalanx
Here the phalanx advances to meet an opposing phalanx in very tight formation, shoulder-to-shoulder and with shields up against the back of the man in front. Only the front three or four ranks could have reached the enemy with their spears. Later, when spears grew much longer, they were probably held underarm.



